

Figurative Language Deep Dive ★

Extended metaphors, personification & layered technique — copy every box below

🔪 WHY THIS WORKSHEET GOES FURTHER THAN THE BASICS

You already know the definitions of simile, metaphor and personification. This worksheet is about the harder skill: spotting figurative language that is **vague, hidden, or stretched across many lines** — the kind GL-style exams use to separate a good answer from a top-band answer. Real exam poems rarely hand you an obvious "the sea was a lion" — they build the comparison slowly, drop hints, and expect you to notice the pattern.

🔪 EXTENDED METAPHOR — THE FULL NOTES

An **extended metaphor** is a single comparison that a poet develops across several lines, a whole stanza, or even the entire poem — rather than a one-line comparison and then moving on.

Example: a poem about grief that keeps returning to storm imagery — "a storm behind my ribs", then later "the thunder hasn't passed", then finally "I am still waiting for the sky to clear" — grief is being compared to a storm throughout, not just once.

HOW TO SPOT ONE	Look for the SAME comparison-idea (e.g. war, weather, machinery, growth, journeys) appearing more than once in different words across the poem.
WHY POETS USE IT	It shows the comparison is central to the poem's meaning, not decoration — it lets the poet explore an idea from several angles.
EXAM TRAP	Students often spot ONE metaphor and stop. Full marks usually needs you to trace it across at least two points in the poem and show how it develops or changes.

Practice habit: whenever you spot a metaphor, ask "does this comparison come back later in the poem, in different words?" If yes — it's extended, and you should mention BOTH appearances in your answer.

STRUCTURE 1 OF 6

Ask these 3 questions whenever you suspect an extended metaphor

1. What are the two things being compared (e.g. grief = storm)?
2. Where else in the poem does this same comparison reappear, in different words?
3. Does the comparison change or develop by the end (e.g. does the "storm" finally pass)? If it does, that development is often the poem's whole message.

🔪 PERSONIFICATION — BEYOND THE BASIC DEFINITION

Personification is giving human qualities, actions, or feelings to something non-human (an object, an animal, nature, an abstract idea like time or fear). GL-style poems often use it in a **subtle** way that's easy to miss.

OBVIOUS PERSONIFICATION	"The wind screamed through the trees." (a human action — screaming — given to wind)
SUBTLE PERSONIFICATION	"The house held its breath." / "The road refused to end." / "Morning arrived, apologetic." — these give human emotion or intention to things that cannot actually feel.
WHY IT MATTERS	Subtle personification often reveals the SPEAKER'S feelings, projected onto the world around them — e.g. "the house held its breath" suggests the speaker feels tense, not that the house is actually alive.

Key insight to copy down: when a poet personifies something, the human quality they choose (angry, tired, patient, nervous) usually reflects the mood of the **SPEAKER** or the overall atmosphere of the poem — not a random detail.

STRUCTURE 2 OF 6

Step-by-step for any personification question

1. Identify the non-human thing being personified.
2. Identify the exact human quality/action given to it.
3. Ask: what does this human quality usually mean/feel like (e.g. "apologetic" = guilty, hesitant)?
4. Link this feeling to the speaker's own emotional state or the poem's mood.
5. Explain the effect: does it make the setting feel alive, threatening, comforting, or sad?

🔪 VAGUE / IMPLIED FIGURATIVE LANGUAGE — THE HARDEST GL SKILL

Sometimes a poem doesn't clearly say "like" or "as" (simile) or directly state "X is Y" (metaphor) — the comparison is only **implied**. This is deliberately the hardest skill on this worksheet, because it's the hardest skill on the real exam.

Example: "Her voice, when it finally came, was paper-thin and folding at the edges." There's no "like" — but "paper-thin" and "folding" implies her voice is being compared to paper: fragile, easily damaged, close to giving way.

CLUE 1	An unusual adjective attached to something that wouldn't normally have it (a "paper" voice, a "glass" smile, a "concrete" silence).
CLUE 2	A verb borrowed from a different context (a voice that "folds", a memory that "cracks", a feeling that "melts").
CLUE 3	Ask yourself: "what real object does this word usually describe?" — then ask why the poet has borrowed it here.

🔪 STRUCTURE 3 — THE BORROWED-WORD METHOD FOR IMPLIED COMPARISONS

STRUCTURE 3 OF 6

Use this whenever a description feels "odd" or unusually specific

1. Find the unusual word (adjective or verb) attached to the subject.
2. Ask: what object or idea does this word normally belong to? (e.g. "folding" normally belongs to paper/fabric.)
3. State the implied comparison directly: "the poet is comparing X to Y."
4. Explain what quality of Y is being borrowed (fragility, coldness, softness, sharpness).
5. Explain the effect this creates for the reader.

🔪 STRUCTURE 4 — DEVICE-STACKING (WHEN SEVERAL TECHNIQUES WORK TOGETHER)

STRUCTURE 4 OF 6

Top-band answers notice more than one device working on the SAME line

1. Read the line slowly and list every device you can see (e.g. metaphor + alliteration + short sentence).
2. Explain each device's own effect briefly.
3. Then explain the COMBINED effect — how do they work together to intensify the meaning?

Example: "Grief gnawed, grey and patient." — metaphor (grief as an animal that "gnaws"), alliteration ("grief", "grey"), and personification (grief being "patient") all combine to make grief feel like a slow, deliberate, living threat.

🔪 STRUCTURE 5 — SYMBOLISM VS. METAPHOR (DON'T CONFUSE THEM)

STRUCTURE 5 OF 6

The key difference to remember

- **Metaphor** = a direct comparison stated in the text ("grief is a storm").
- **Symbolism** = an object in the poem that represents a bigger, often unstated idea, without the poem ever saying "this represents that" (a wilting flower appearing throughout a poem about a dying relationship, without ever being called a metaphor).
- Symbolism is usually built through an object that REPEATS or is given unusual attention across the poem — always ask "why does this object keep appearing?"

STRUCTURE 6 OF 6

Combine everything above into one answer format

1. Name the device (or say "implied comparison" if it's vague/unstated).
2. Quote the exact phrase.
3. State what is being compared to what.
4. Explain the quality being borrowed from the comparison.
5. Link to mood, speaker's feelings, or the poem's theme.
6. If it's an extended metaphor, mention its second appearance too.

 PRACTICE EXTRACTS — ANNOTATE THESE NOW

"The old man's hands were maps of every winter he had crossed."

What is being compared? _____ What quality is borrowed? _____

"Her laughter cracked the silence like the first ice of the season, sharp and surprising."

Device(s) present: _____ Effect: _____

"The city held its breath before the storm, waiting, as we all were, for something to break."

What human quality is given to the city? _____ What does this suggest about the mood? _____